

MINERS

By MARK LEIBSON
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LAS CRUCES, N.M. — Gary Kobatt's hopes for a fly ball were fulfilled. Unfortunately, the ball went five feet further than Kobatt had wanted.

The University of Texas at El Paso hurler was sailing along with a slim 4-3 lead in the bottom of the sixth inning when Phil Rector came to bat with a teammate on base.

"My slider was working good and I was going for a pop-up. He (Rector) popped it up all right. Five feet too much though," said Kobatt after Rector's late two-run homer to left field handed New Mexico State a 5-4 win in the nightcap and a split of the doubleheader with UTEP Wednesday.

The Miners won the opener 8-2.

"I made the mistake of giving our younger kids a chance to play," admitted Miner Coach Andy Cohen after losing the second game. "They made some errors and there was a time we had a suicide squeeze going and the kid completely missed the ball which cost us a run."

UTEP acquired its four runs in the third and fourth innings on seven singles and an Aggie error, one of 10 miscues New Mexico State made on its home field.

The Miners failed to push across an insurance run in the fifth when Cohen called for the suicide squeeze with Glenn Villarreal at third. Shortstop Luie Morales missed the bunt attempt and Villarreal was tagged out at the plate.

NMSU's first three runs were all unearned as a result of a pair of errors by Jim DiAngelo, who was playing shortstop until relieved by Morales in the fifth.

But with two outs in the sixth and Cliff Olander at second as the result of a single and stolen base, Rector unloaded his third home run of the season over Steve Dau's head in left.

Aggie reliever Grady Oxford, who hurled two and two-thirds innings of perfect ball, picked up his second win of the season while Kobatt's record dropped to 0-2.

Keith Rushing and Terry Dillingham were the big sticks in the opener as the Miners rapped 10 hits and used seven Aggie errors to account for eight runs. Meanwhile steady Jeff Hogan won his third game against no defeats.

The Miners scored a pair of runs in each of the first two innings. Dillingham singled with two outs in the first and raced home on Villarreal's triple down the right field line. Villarreal followed when losing pitcher Jay Minturn threw away a grounder at first.

Dillingham's double in the